JOEL'S LAB HACKS

How to Read Your Labs Like a Pro

The 14 numbers that matter most for your pressure, your sugar, your stress, and your blood. Short and plain, with a trick to remember each one.

> *Your numbers are signals. They are not sentences.*
>
> Joel Polley, RN

A lab report can look like a wall of numbers. It is not. It is a short list of signals. Each one points at one of three things: your Stress, your Sugar, or your Sodium. Think of three faucets over one sink. All three pour into your blood pressure. Your labs show you which faucet is open.

Three rules before you read one number

1. **Find the range column.** Every report has a column called "reference range." That is the lab's normal range. It shows what most healthy people score. It is your measuring stick.
2. **Only compare to YOUR report.** Labs use different machines. The range printed on your paper is the one to trust. Not this guide. Not the internet.
3. **H and L are questions, not answers.** H means above the range. L means below it. A flag means "ask about this." It does not mean something is wrong.

PRO MOVE: THE PEN TRICK

Ask for a paper copy of your labs. Circle every H and every L with a pen. Next to each circle, write one question. Bring that paper to your visit. Use the same lab each time, so you can see the pattern over time. The pattern matters more than any one number.

What's inside

1. **Faucet one, Sugar:** A1c, fasting glucose, triglycerides.
2. **Faucet two, Sodium and the minerals:** sodium, potassium, magnesium.
3. **Faucet three, Stress:** hs-CRP, TSH, vitamin D.
4. **The plumbing, Kidneys and heart:** eGFR, creatinine and BUN, LDL and HDL.
5. **The blood itself, Anemia and infection:** hemoglobin and hematocrit, white blood cells. Then all 14 on one pocket card.

FAUCET ONE

Sugar

Your blood pressure problem may be a blood sugar problem wearing a disguise. High insulin tells your kidneys to hold on to salt. Salt holds water. Water is pressure. These three numbers show the sugar faucet.

1 A1c

your 3-month sugar report card

A1c shows your average blood sugar over about 90 days. One bad meal cannot hide here, and one good day cannot fix it. It shows the pattern.

THE NUMBERS

Under 5.7 is normal. 5.7 to 6.4 is the pre-diabetes range. 6.5 and up is the diabetes range. Your doctor confirms it with a second test. (American Diabetes Association)

LAB HACK

Remember two highway exits: 5.7 and 6.5. Pass exit 5.7 and you are in the warning zone. Pass exit 6.5 and you are in the diabetes range. Pro trick: an A1c of 6 means your sugar averages about 126. Each extra point adds about 29.

WHAT MOVES IT

A 10-minute walk after each meal. Eat your vegetables and beans first, then the starch. Cut sugary drinks.

2 Fasting glucose

this morning's sugar

This is your blood sugar first thing in the morning, before you eat. It shows how your body handled the night.

THE NUMBERS

Under 100 is normal. 100 to 125 is the pre-diabetes range. 126 and up is the diabetes range. (American Diabetes Association; MedlinePlus lists 70 to 99 as normal)

LAB HACK

A nursing-school line: "Between 70 and 100, I am in the sweet spot." Say it out loud until it sticks.

WHAT MOVES IT

Finish eating 3 hours before bed. A plant-based breakfast with fiber, like oats with berries and flax, within an hour of waking.

ASK YOUR DOCTOR FIRST

If you take diabetes medicine, ask your doctor before you change when you eat.

3 Triglycerides

fat made from extra sugar

Triglycerides are fat floating in your blood. Extra sugar and white starch turn into this fat. It often shows up here before it shows up on the scale.

THE NUMBERS

Under 150 is healthy. 150 to 199 is borderline. 200 to 499 is high. 500 and up is very high. (MedlinePlus)

LAB HACK

150 is the speed limit. Over 150 can be a sign the sugar faucet is open, even when your A1c still looks fine. Ask your doctor why.

WHAT MOVES IT

Cut sweet drinks and white bread. Eat beans, oats, and leafy greens. Walk after meals.

FAUCET TWO

Sodium and the minerals

Eating more potassium and less salt helps pressure. Think of a seesaw: salt on one end, potassium on the other. Magnesium is the mineral nobody checks. Ask for all three.

4 Sodium

salt and water balance

This is the salt in your blood. Your body works hard to keep it steady. When you eat too much salt, it holds extra water to water the salt down. That extra water is pressure.

THE NUMBERS

135 to 145 is the usual range. (MedlinePlus)

LAB HACK

140, give or take 5. One more hack: a normal sodium does NOT mean your salt is fine. Blood sodium stays steady even when you eat too much salt. Look at your pressure and your swelling, not only this number.

WHAT MOVES IT

Cook at home. Read labels. Over 70 percent of the salt we eat comes from packaged and restaurant food, not the shaker. (CDC)

5 Potassium

salt's opposite

Potassium helps your muscles, your nerves, and your heartbeat. It helps your body let go of extra salt.

THE NUMBERS

3.7 to 5.2 is the MedlinePlus range. Many labs print 3.5 to 5.0. Use your report's range.

LAB HACK

A nursing-school trick: "Bananas cost $3.50 to $5.00 a bunch." That is the 3.5 to 5.0 range. Bananas already mean potassium to most people, so the number sticks.

WHAT MOVES IT

Two servings of dark leafy greens a day. White beans, sweet potato, avocado, and squash. Food first, always.

ASK YOUR DOCTOR FIRST

If you have kidney disease, or you take a water pill that holds potassium in your body, ask your doctor before you change the potassium you eat or take.

6 Magnesium

the mineral nobody checks

Magnesium helps your blood vessels relax. High sugar flushes magnesium out in your urine, and low magnesium makes the sugar problem worse. It is a loop.

THE NUMBERS

1.7 to 2.2 mg/dL is the usual range. (MedlinePlus)

LAB HACK

Only about 1 percent of your magnesium is in your blood. So a "normal" number can still mean your body has little stored. A LOW number is a loud signal. Ask for this test by name.

WHAT MOVES IT

Pumpkin seeds, spinach, black beans, almonds, and whole grains. Magnesium is food first.

ASK YOUR DOCTOR FIRST

If you have kidney disease, ask your doctor before taking any magnesium supplement.

FAUCET THREE

Stress

There is no cortisol line on a normal lab panel. Your labs can come back "normal" while your pressure climbs. Stress shows up in your body first: waking at 2 to 4 AM, feeling tired but wired, and a tight jaw. These three numbers are the closest helpers.

7 hs-CRP

the inflammation smoke alarm

CRP is a protein your liver makes when something inside you is irritated or swollen. That is inflammation. Stress, poor sleep, and sugar all set the alarm off. The "hs" means the extra-sensitive test, the one used for heart risk.

THE NUMBERS

Under 1.0 is low risk. 1.0 to 3.0 is average. Over 3.0 is high. (American Heart Association bands, as listed by MedlinePlus)

LAB HACK

One and three. Under 1 is calm. Over 3 is a fire. Ask for "high-sensitivity CRP," not plain CRP.

WHAT MOVES IT

Sleep by 10 PM. Box breathing for 4 minutes when stress hits. Colorful plants on every plate.

8 TSH

the thyroid's manager

TSH is the signal your brain sends to your thyroid. The thyroid sets your body's speed. A slow thyroid can mean tiredness, weight gain, and higher pressure.

THE NUMBERS

0.4 to 4.8 is a common range. Labs differ, and experts argue about the top number. (MedlinePlus)

LAB HACK

The manager moves OPPOSITE the worker. If the thyroid (the worker) slows down, TSH (the manager) goes UP and calls louder. So a HIGH TSH usually means a SLOW thyroid. Pro trick: get your blood draw in the morning. TSH changes through the day.

WHAT MOVES IT

Sleep, sunlight, and a steady eating rhythm. Ask for free T3 and free T4 with it, so you see the whole picture.

9 Vitamin D

the sunshine vitamin

Low vitamin D travels with higher pressure, low mood, tired bones, and more colds. Most of us who work indoors run low.

THE NUMBERS

Experts do not fully agree. Many call 30 to 80 ng/mL (a lab unit) normal. Under 20 is low. (MedlinePlus; Endocrine Society)

LAB HACK

Twenty is low. Thirty is where most doctors are happy. Ask for "25-hydroxy vitamin D." That is the real test.

WHAT MOVES IT

Midday sun on bare arms most days. Ask your doctor how much sun is safe for you. Mushrooms set out in the sun make their own vitamin D. Ask your doctor about a dose if you are low.

THE PLUMBING

Kidneys and heart

Your kidneys and your blood pressure push on each other. High pressure wears the kidneys down. Tired kidneys raise the pressure. Watch these three.

10 eGFR

your kidney filter score

eGFR estimates how well your kidneys filter your blood. Think of it like a score out of about 100. Higher is better.

THE NUMBERS

90 and up is normal. 60 to 89 is a mild drop. Under 60 for 3 months can be a sign of kidney disease. Under 15 is kidney failure. Your doctor decides. (National Kidney Foundation)

LAB HACK

Highway exits again: 90, 60, 30, 15. Stay above exit 60. Drink water the day before your blood draw, unless your doctor limits your fluids. Being dry can fake a lower score.

WHAT MOVES IT

Keep your pressure and sugar in range. Drink water through the day, unless your doctor limits your fluids. Ask your doctor how often you can take painkillers like ibuprofen.

11 Creatinine and BUN

the waste your kidneys clear

Creatinine is muscle waste. BUN is protein waste. Healthy kidneys clear both. When they climb, the kidneys are asking for help.

THE NUMBERS

Creatinine: men 0.7 to 1.3, women 0.5 to 0.95 mg/dL. BUN: 6 to 20 mg/dL. (MedlinePlus)

LAB HACK

A high BUN can mean you are low on water. It can have other causes too. Ask your doctor. Creatinine that rises over several reports is the one to ask about. Look at the pattern, not one blood draw.

WHAT MOVES IT

Water, pressure control, and sugar control. Those three protect the kidneys more than anything else.

12 Cholesterol: LDL and HDL

the carriers

Cholesterol rides in carriers. LDL drops it off in your artery walls. HDL picks it back up and carries it away.

THE NUMBERS

Total under 200. LDL under 100. HDL 60 and up is best. HDL under 40 (men) or under 50 (women) is low. (MedlinePlus)

LAB HACK

H is Healthy. L is Lousy. You want Healthy high and Lousy low. Careful: these letters are the names HDL and LDL. They are not the H and L flags on your report. Pro trick: look at triglycerides on the same page. High triglycerides can be a sign sugar is part of the story.

WHAT MOVES IT

Oats, beans, flax, nuts, olive oil, and a rainbow of vegetables. Walk after meals. Sleep.

THE BLOOD ITSELF

Anemia and infection

These two come from the CBC, the complete blood count. Low red cells means anemia, and you feel it as tired, short of breath, and dizzy when you stand. High white cells can mean your body is fighting something. Both can drain your energy.

13 Hemoglobin and hematocrit

your red blood cells

Hemoglobin is the part of a red blood cell that carries oxygen. Hematocrit is how much of your blood is red blood cells. Low means anemia. Tired, pale, cold hands, and a racing heart are the signs.

THE NUMBERS

Hemoglobin: women 12.1 to 15.1, men 13.8 to 17.2 g/dL. Hematocrit: women 34 to 43 percent, men 37 to 48 percent. (MedlinePlus)

LAB HACK

Twelve and fourteen are the round numbers to remember. Your report's own range is the real line. Pro trick: hematocrit is about 3 times the hemoglobin. Hemoglobin 12 means hematocrit near 36. If the two are far apart, ask why.

WHAT MOVES IT

Iron from plants: lentils, white beans, spinach, pumpkin seeds, and blackstrap molasses. Add vitamin C in the same meal, like orange or bell pepper, so the iron gets in. Ask your doctor to check ferritin and B12 if you are low.

14 White blood cells (WBC)

your defense team

White blood cells fight infection. The count goes up when your body is fighting something. It can also go up with stress, inflammation, and some medicines. It goes down when your defenses are low.

THE NUMBERS

4,500 to 11,000 per microliter, often printed as 4.5 to 11.0. (MedlinePlus)

LAB HACK

Four and a half to eleven. Over 11 can mean a fight is on: infection, inflammation, or heavy stress. Under 4.5 can mean low defenses. Either one is a question for your doctor, not a verdict.

WHAT MOVES IT

Sleep, water, sunlight, and a plant-rich plate. If it is high with a fever, chills, or a wound, call your doctor the same day.

Three questions to ask at your next visit

1. **Which of my numbers moved since last time?**
2. **Which one do you want to see move first?**
3. **What is the goal number for me?**

BRING YOUR LABS TO OUR CALL

Upload a photo of your report in your portal at portal.bpquiz.com, or bring it to our next 1:1. I will explain what each number means in plain words. Your doctor decides what to do about it.

PRINT THIS PAGE

The pocket card

Fourteen labs, the good zone, and the hack. Use the range on your own report when the two differ.

LAB	GOOD ZONE	THE HACK
A1c	Under 5.7	Exits 5.7 and 6.5
Fasting glucose	70 to 99	70 to 100 is the sweet spot
Triglycerides	Under 150	150 is the speed limit
Sodium	135 to 145	140, give or take 5
Potassium	3.7 to 5.2	Bananas, $3.50 to $5.00
Magnesium	1.7 to 2.2	Only 1% is in the blood
hs-CRP	Under 1.0	One is calm, three is fire
TSH	0.4 to 4.8	High TSH = slow thyroid
Vitamin D	30 to 80	Twenty is low
eGFR	90 and up	Exits 90, 60, 30, 15
Creatinine / BUN	Your range / 6 to 20	BUN over 20? Ask why
LDL / HDL	Under 100 / 60 and up	H is Healthy, L is Lousy
Hemoglobin	Women 12.1+, men 13.8+	Hematocrit is 3x hemoglobin
WBC	4.5 to 11	Over 11, a fight may be on

Educational content only. Not medical advice, diagnosis, or treatment. Joel Polley is a Registered Nurse, not a prescribing physician. We never change your medications. Never start, stop, or adjust a medication without your doctor. Reference ranges come from the American Diabetes Association, the American Heart Association, the National Kidney Foundation, the Endocrine Society, the CDC, and MedlinePlus (U.S. National Library of Medicine), as published in November 2026. Your lab's printed range is the one that applies to you.

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